

line of ₹300 crore. Since then, Wipro Consumer's revenues have grown over 30 times, but only Santoor and lighting survive from the 2003 list.

Santoor fetches revenues of ₹2,650 crore, or over a quarter of total revenues, though it had a rocky start. Santoor was test-marketed in Bengaluru (then Bangalore) in 1984-85 but flopped. Wipro then decided to take it national. By 1989, after a lot of effort, the brand was selling just 3,000 tonnes annually in a total market of 240,000 tonnes. Hindustan Lever Ltd (HLL) dominated the landscape with its Lifebuoy, Hamam, Rexona and Lux brands.

Wipro decided to do some consumer research afresh. It turned out to be a smart idea: the research showed that Wipro could work up some extra lather by selling the sandalwood soap as something that gives women "younger-looking skin". That proposition made history with the "Mummy?" television campaign in which a Santoor-using woman looks too young to be the mother of a child running around. The TV commercial is still around (the mothers have changed; the brand's growth hasn't).

Ambi Parameswaran, then at FCB Ulka heading the account and now the Founder of brand-building.com, says soap advertising historically showed young women. "Santoor was a clear disruption and focussed on the mom. It was not just about the skin but making a woman feel young," he says. Though Santoor's sales took off to hit 10,000 tonnes, it had plateaued in 1992-93. Two ads were shot, with a woman in leotards for north India and salwar attire for the South. Launched in November 1994, it hardly made a difference to the numbers. The eureka moment was when the leotard campaign was aired in the (more conservative) South, and there was no looking back.

"Research could not have thrown up something like that. In many ways, Santoor has been a story of accidents," says Agrawal, who is clear that the brand's eventual success was the first tipping point for Wipro Consumer.



CUT TO MID-1995 WHEN Santoor was doing well but without big advertising money. Agrawal, then head of marketing, took a chance by throwing all his media spend on just five states—Andhra Pradesh (it was then unified), Maharashtra, Odisha, Kerala, and Karnataka. His sales force in the North was miffed. "They said the entire system would collapse, but I stuck to my decision. AP and Maharashtra

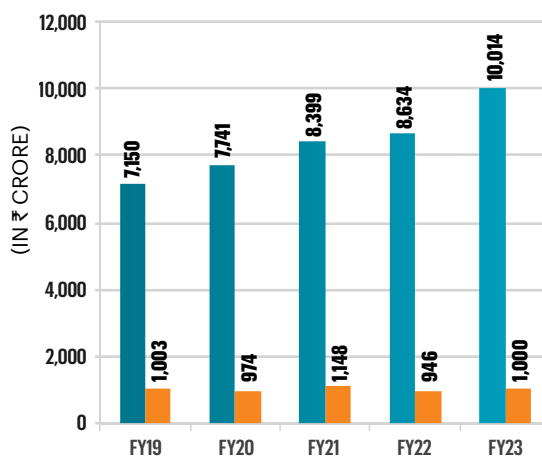
THE RISE OF THE CONSUMER BIZ

- 1** Wipro Consumer was hived off from Wipro Ltd in 2013 as a part of the demerger of its non-IT businesses
- 2** From revenues of ₹300 crore in FY03, it has crossed ₹10,000 crore in FY23, a growth of over 30x
- 3** Its flagship brand Santoor alone clocked revenues of ₹2,650 crore in FY23; it is the second-largest in the segment after HUL's Lifebuoy
- 4** To date, Wipro Consumer has made 14 buyouts; its revenue is split evenly between India and overseas markets
- 5** The next step is to crack the foods market, both in spices and snacks. It will acquire brands for spices and focus on south India for snacks

THE JOURNEY TO ₹10,000 CRORE

> Wipro Consumer's revenues have grown at a CAGR of 7 per cent between FY19 and FY23

> But its profits have remained flat in those years



● REVENUES ● PROFITS

SOURCE WIPRO ENTERPRISES ANNUAL REPORT